

MANAGEMENT FUNDAMENTALS

Product, Project & Program Management

Understanding the three disciplines — what they are and what each person does

The Big Picture

Three different jobs. Three different questions they answer.

PRODUCT

"What should we build?"

Focuses on the WHY and WHAT.
Defines what the product is,
who it's for, and why it matters.

*Example: Deciding to add a
'dark mode' feature to an app.*

PROJECT

"How do we build it?"

Focuses on the HOW and WHEN.
Manages tasks, timelines,
budget, and delivery.

*Example: Building the dark
mode feature by Dec 1st,
within budget.*

PROGRAM

"How do it all fit together?"

Focuses on the BIGGER PICTURE.
Coordinates multiple related
projects toward one big goal.

*Example: Overseeing 5 app
projects to deliver a full
platform upgrade.*



Product Management

What is the FIELD?

Product management is the discipline of deciding **what a product should be and why it should exist.**

Think of it like being the "voice of the customer" inside a company. Product managers figure out what problems people have and turn that into a product or feature.

 Real Life: Imagine you work at a food delivery company. A product manager noticed customers kept saying, "I don't know how far away my order is." They decided to build a live order-tracking map. That decision — and the strategy behind it — is product management.

What does a Product Manager DO?

-  Talks to customers to understand their problems
-  Decides which features to build (and which NOT to build)
-  Writes requirements — explains what the product should do
-  Works closely with designers, developers & business teams
-  Tracks whether the product is succeeding
-  Adjusts the plan based on feedback & data



Project Management

What is the FIELD?

Project management is the discipline of planning and delivering a specific piece of work **on time, within budget, and to the right quality.**

A project has a clear start and end date. It is temporary — once the goal is achieved, the project is done.

 Real Life: The same food delivery company says, "Let's build that tracking map in 3 months with a team of 4." A project manager creates the timeline, assigns tasks, removes obstacles, and makes sure the feature is delivered on time. That is project management.

What does a Project Manager DO?

-  Creates a detailed project plan with timelines
-  Assigns tasks to the right people
-  Identifies risks before they become problems
-  Tracks budget and resources
-  Sends regular updates to stakeholders
-  Makes sure the project is delivered as promised



Program Management

What is the FIELD?

Program management coordinates **multiple related projects that together achieve a larger strategic goal.**

If a project is one chapter, a program is the whole book. A program can run for years and includes many smaller projects that depend on each other.

🌐 Real Life: The company wants to launch a full "Super App" — tracking, payments, loyalty rewards, and driver ratings. Each is its own project. The program manager makes sure all five projects align, share resources, and don't conflict with each other.

What does a Program Manager DO?

- 📖 Sets the overall roadmap across all projects
- 🎯 Makes sure projects work together, not against each other
- 🏛️ Reports to senior leadership on the big picture
- ⚖️ Resolves conflicts between project teams
- 📁 Manages shared budgets and resources
- 🎯 Ensures all projects serve the same strategic goal

How Are They Different? A Quick Comparison

 Main Focus	What & Why	How & When	Big Picture Strategy
 Time Horizon	Ongoing / Long-term	Temporary (has end)	Long-term (years)
 Scope	One product	One project	Many projects
 Reports to	Business/Strategy	PM/Stakeholders	Senior Leadership
 Key Skill	Customer empathy	Execution & detail	Strategic thinking
 Real-life job	App Product Manager	Office Renovation PM	City Transport Director

Real-Life Analogy: Opening a Restaurant Chain

Same goal. Three different roles.

Product Manager

"What kind of restaurant?"

Researches what food people want, studies competitors, decides it will be a fast-casual healthy bowl restaurant. Defines the menu strategy and who the customers are.

Defines the **VISION**

Project Manager

"Build the first location"

Gets permits, hires contractors, buys equipment, trains staff. Makes sure the first restaurant opens on Day 1 of Month 3, within the \$200K budget.

Delivers the **EXECUTION**

Program Manager

"Open 10 restaurants nationwide"

Coordinates location scouting, construction, hiring, and marketing across all 10 cities. Makes sure each opening doesn't compete for the same contractors or budget.

Oversees the **SCALE**

Key Takeaways

1

Product Manager asks: "What should we build and why?" — they focus on the customer and the strategy.

2

Project Manager asks: "How do we get it done on time?" — they focus on tasks, timelines, and delivery.

3

Program Manager asks: "How do all the pieces fit together?" — they lead across multiple projects to hit a big goal.

4

All three are needed. In a small company, one person may do all three. In a large company, they are separate roles.

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The key difference: Product = What & Why · Project = How & When · Program = The Big Strategic View